

County Administration Workshop: June 30, 2026

1:30 p.m. – Board of Commissioners Conference Room

Attending: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:30 p.m.

1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest

The board declared there are no potential conflicts of interest.

2. Department Business

a. Assessor

1. Amendment No. 2 to IGA No. PO-44000-00020617 with State of Oregon to provide services to the public as an agent for Department of Consumer and Business Services (DCBS)

Chris Parton, Assessor, presented Amendment No. 2 to the existing Intergovernmental Agreement between Josephine County and the Oregon Department of Consumer and Business Services. Mr. Parton explained that the amendment was primarily administrative in nature and updated contact information and the agreement's expiration date. Approval would allow the Assessor's Office to continue providing manufactured home transaction services on behalf of the State of Oregon. *Commissioner Martin moved to approve Amendment No. 2 to IGA No. PO-44000-00020617 with State of Oregon to provide services to the public as an agent for Department of Consumer and Business Services (DCBS). Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.*

b. Public Works

1. Old Fuel Station Decommission Change Order

Richard Pike, Public Works provided details of the requested approval of a change order increasing the contract by \$29,810.72 for the former Public Works fuel station decommissioning project. Mr. Pike explained that additional excavation became necessary after fuel odors were discovered beyond the anticipated excavation limits, requiring additional concrete removal, soil sampling, hauling, and environmental testing. Although the work exceeded the original contract amount, testing confirmed contamination was significantly less extensive than initially feared, and the project has now been completed successfully. Commissioners discussed the importance of performing the additional environmental investigation to ensure contaminated soils were properly addressed. Mr. Pike advised that all required remediation had been completed and no additional future work is anticipated. *Commissioner Martin moved to approve the Old Fuel Station Decommission Change Order. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.*

2. Exemption of Robco Invoices from Board Approval

Mr. Pike presented a request to exempt recurring Robco chip seal material invoices from future Board approval. He explained that annual purchases of chip seal rock occur each construction season, are budgeted through the Road Fund, and occasionally exceed the County's signing authority threshold despite representing routine operational expenses. Commissioners discussed maintaining Board oversight while minimizing unnecessary administrative delays. Commissioner Richardson expressed a desire to further consider the request and suggested discussing the matter directly with Public Works Director Rob Brandes upon his return. Commissioners also discussed maintaining consistency with the County's Contract Signing Authority Policy. Following discussion, the Board approved payment of the current Robco invoice but agreed to table the broader exemption request for additional discussion at a future Administration Workshop. *Commissioner Martin moved to approve Exemption of Robco Invoices from Board Approval. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.*

3. Report and Recommendation to Purchase Self-Propelled Brooms.

Mr. Pike presented Public Works' recommendation to purchase replacement self-propelled street brooms previously approved within the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget. He explained that the existing equipment has exceeded its expected service life, having remained in operation for approximately sixteen years despite an anticipated ten-year lifespan. Staff also reported that manufacturer pricing would increase beginning July 1, making prompt approval financially advantageous.

Commissioners discussed replacement schedules for major Public Works equipment, resale of retired equipment through public auction, and whether large capital purchases already included in the adopted budget should continue returning to the Board for approval. Chair Smith expressed support for continuing Board review of significant capital purchases exceeding approximately \$50,000 to promote transparency and public awareness while allowing smaller routine purchases to proceed administratively. *Commissioner Richardson moved to approve Report and Recommendation to Purchase Self-Propelled Brooms. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.*

3. BOARD BUSINESS

a. Anne G. Basker Auditorium Rental Application – Josephine County Court-Interview Panel 7/15/26

The Board reviewed an application submitted by the Josephine County Circuit Court requesting use of the Anne G. Basker Auditorium for an interview panel scheduled for July 15, 2026. The application was approved without objection.

b. Board Order No. 2026-039; In the Matter of Separating the Information Technology and Emergency Management Functions of Josephine County and Establishing Separate Department Director Classifications

The Board discussed the proposed Board Order separating the Information Technology and Emergency Management functions into two independent departments. Commissioners reviewed the historical creation of the combined Technology/Emergency Services Director position and discussed restoring separate departmental leadership. Commissioner Smith requested that Firewise also be considered as a separate organizational function and discussed whether it should remain administratively connected to Emergency Management. Commissioners also discussed the distinction between director and manager classifications, organizational reporting relationships, staffing levels, and historical County organizational structures. Legal Counsel advised that the Board could separate Information Technology and Emergency Management immediately while considering Firewise separately at a later date. Following discussion, Commissioners agreed additional review was appropriate before taking formal action. The matter was tabled to allow staff to revise the proposed Board Order and include discussion regarding the future organizational placement of Firewise.

c. Board Order No. 2026-020; In the Matter of Suspending the Acceptance of Applications for Mineral Exploration Permits and Mining Leases.

Planning Director Dave Streeter presented discussion regarding continued suspension of applications for mineral exploration permits and mining leases. Mr. Streeter explained that ongoing litigation involving the County's existing Mining Ordinance remains unresolved and recommended temporarily suspending new applications while the ordinance is evaluated. Commissioners discussed the current litigation, concerns regarding provisions contained within the existing ordinance, recommendations previously developed by County staff and the Mining Advisory Committee, and potential alternatives, including handling future applications on a case-by-case basis rather than under the current ordinance. Commissioners expressed a desire to review the competing draft ordinance revisions and receive additional information from staff before extending the suspension. Following discussion, the Board directed staff to prepare a revised Board Order extending the suspension for an additional three months while the Board evaluates potential revisions to the Mining Ordinance in consultation with the Mining Advisory Committee. The matter was tabled until the next Administration Workshop.

4. OTHER

Commissioner Martin discussed the need to designate interim leadership within the Human Resources Department while recruitment for a permanent Human Resources Director continues. Commissioners discussed operational needs, including approval of personnel documents and maintaining day-to-day departmental operations. *Commissioner Richardson moved to appoint Natalie Eckhardt-Doupe as Interim Human Resources Director. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon Roll Call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes; Commissioner Martin – Yes; Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 3-0.* Commissioner Richardson reported that he has begun evaluating pilot projects utilizing automation and artificial intelligence technologies to improve operational efficiency within County departments. He emphasized that the initiative is intended to assist employees by reducing repetitive administrative tasks rather than replacing staff. Discussion included potential software enhancements, workflow automation, integration with existing County software systems, and opportunities to develop internally designed tools tailored to County operations. Commissioners discussed the expanding use of artificial intelligence within local government, including opportunities to improve data entry, document management, reporting, and grant administration. While expressing optimism regarding future efficiencies, Commissioners also emphasized the importance of maintaining human oversight and implementing new technologies cautiously to ensure accuracy and accountability.

5. ADDITIONAL SUBJECT MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS/ANNOUNCEMENTS:

The meeting adjourned at 2:30 p.m.